

Research synthesis — what to do next

eBay Valuation Bot · Grok + Claude-chat results reviewed · 17 June 2026

Decision: build against eBay's official Browse API first. Both research passes back it. The deeper Claude run verified, field by field, that Browse returns exactly what we need.

What the two passes agreed on

Grok rated managed scrapers (Apify) as the quick practical route and put the official API second because approval can drag. The deeper Claude run went further and checked the docs: Browse's search response returns current bid, bid count, end timestamp, item ID, listing URL and title for auctions, filtered to eBay UK, sorted ending-soonest, free under 5,000 calls a day. That's our whole wishlist from one first-party source. It demotes scrapers to a backup.

Neither pass could verify a single RapidAPI provider that reliably returns live auction bid and end time for the UK. That matches the dud I already bought. So that route is dead, confirmed twice.

Why this is bigger than it reads

We already built the Browse client. `--mode browse` exists in the code and calls the exact endpoint, filter and marketplace header the research recommends. The "hard problem" the last four sessions circled is mostly an access form, not a coding job. Remaining work: get the keyset, clear eBay's compliance step, flip the workflow from `thirdparty` to `browse`.

Securing the keyset (the side piece you asked about)

1. Developer account — free, ~1 day. [you've signed up](#)
2. Create a production keyset → App ID + Cert ID.
3. Clear the account-deletion notification compliance step. This is the one real hoop: eBay wants an HTTPS endpoint that acknowledges its deletion pings before the keyset goes live. Cheap to stand up.
4. Add `EBAY_APP_ID` + `EBAY_CERT_ID` as repo secrets, run `--mode browse`.

Not a business? Fine. Membership is open to individuals and the default limits are sized for small builders. Being atypical can slow account approval, not block it. Describe the app as a read-only buyer research tool, not a sniper.

watchcount.com — skip it

It's a consumer site for most-watched items, not a data feed. No clean way to pull current bid plus end time programmatically. More steps, worse data. The Browse API is both easier and better. Same verdict for eBay RSS feeds: they refresh every ~30 min and hide anything ending within ~15 min, useless for "ending soon".

What the next deep-research (what to sell) will add — and what would change the plan

The data question is nearly closed. The open one is now **what to sell**. The new prompt digs into category choice and the bad-listing angle, weighted to your real constraints: high margin per flip, low volume, little time, limited storage. Two findings would move the needle. First, if a category beats graded cards on margin-per-flip while keeping a clean enough identity to value automatically, we re-point the bot — category is already a parameter, so that's config, not a rewrite. Second, if bad-listing arbitrage holds up (poorly pictured or described lots that buyers skip), the model needs to cope with thin, scruffy listings: fewer comps, looser title matching, more weight on confidence. Right now it's tuned for clean ones. That's a concrete change to the gate, not a vague ambition.

Backup if Browse access snags: Apify `data_ops_main/ebay-uk-scraper` for a UK proof-of-concept. Avoid RapidAPI scrapers and RSS for ending-soon logic (verified twice). Full results saved alongside this file as `RESEARCH-results-grok.md` and `RESEARCH-results-claude-chat.md`.